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Court battles hit taxpayer wallets

Chicago’s legal strategy on flood of reversed-conviction suits – private attorneys, drawn-out fights – adds millions to costs

By Joe Mahr and Jason Meisner
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Thomas Sierra spent 22 years in prison on a murder conviction before it was overturned in 2018 — only to face another long legal battle.

Like others who said they were framed by Reynaldo Guevara — a notorious police detective with a long alleged history of fabricated line-ups, beatings and coerced confessions — Sierra filed a lawsuit seeking compensation that could help him rebuild his life. But instead of nego-

SPECIAL REPORT

tiating with Sierra, the city spent more than six years paying a team of private lawyers to challenge nearly every aspect of his case.

In 2023, after years of legal warfare, Sierra’s attorneys offered to settle the lawsuit for \$14.7 million. The city refused. Not until a judge was about to force a trial, in early 2025, did the city call off its hired lawyers and agree to a deal. By then, Sierra’s price to walk away had risen to \$17.5 million.

The city’s long battle resulted in a worse deal for taxpayers, who also had to shell out more than

\$3 million in fees for the outside lawyers.

In a recent interview, Sierra told the Tribune he would have been happy to settle his lawsuit for less than half of what the city ultimately agreed to pay — if lawyers had made him an early offer instead of spending so much time and money trying to argue the police had it right all along.

“If they would have came (to me) years ago, man, they would probably save the city way more money, and I would have been on my way,”

See **COSTS** on Page A8



Thomas Sierra was exonerated after spending 22 years in prison on a murder conviction. The city fought his lawsuit for more than six years before agreeing to a \$17.5 million settlement. **BRIAN CASSELLA/TRIBUNE**



WEATHERING THE STORM

Illinois farmers brace for another bruising season as the war in Iran drives up prices for fertilizer

By Christiana Freitag | CHICAGO TRIBUNE

From sunrise to well past sundown, Rodney Bushmeyer has been driving his tractor over freshly turned soil on his western Illinois farm, planting soybean seeds. He has covered nearly 800 acres. But with another 2,200 acres to go, spring planting season is far from over.

Bushmeyer has been cultivating fields in Hull for over 50 years, growing corn, soybeans and wheat on land that’s been farmed by his father and grandfather before him. Like many other Illinois farmers, Bushmeyer had already applied nitrogen fertilizer to the ground last fall to prepare corn crops for planting.

But as the Iran war enters its fifth week and fertilizer prices surge, he’s not sure he will be able to afford additional applications that could boost his crop production.

“We’ll put some fertilizer on after the crop comes up,” Bushmeyer said. “But if the price stays where it is now, we may not. We may need to sacrifice yield for it, but it’s a balancing act.”

In early March, Iran closed the Strait of Hormuz, a vital shipping route between the Persian Gulf and the Gulf of Oman, to global commercial traffic due to U.S. and Israeli strikes. The disruption has driven up the cost of nitrogen-based synthetic fertilizers such as urea and ammonia — essential for corn production across the Midwest.

From large commercial operations to small-scale organic plots, farmers across Illinois and the country are trying to weather the sharp spike in agricultural costs driven by a conflict thousands of miles from their

Above: Bryce Bushmeyer, left, 40, adjusts a bin of soybean seed while his father, Rodney Bushmeyer, 69, both of Hull, Illinois, sit atop a seed tender at the Bushmeyer farm in Hull on Wednesday. **JOSH BOLAND/TRIBUNE**

See **FARMS** on Page A6

WILL COUNTY

On front line of fight over a sprawling solar farm

Some residents are cashing in; others fear being surrounded

By John Lippert and Alicia Fabbre
FOR THE CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The solar power company offered Alan Mundt more and more money to allow a power line to cross one of his farm fields near the village of Manhattan. He kept saying no, even when the bidding reached \$3 million.

Earthrise Energy needed to cross Mundt’s land because he lives near a power plant the company bought four years ago to be the central distribution hub for a new solar farm stretching 45 square miles across southern Will County.

Mundt said no because the work could have ruined the underground clay drainage pipes installed a century ago by his grandfather and great-grandfather, who dug the trenches by hand.

Excess rainwater flows through the pipes, or tiles as farmers call them, as the fields slope gently west toward the Des Plaines River. Without proper drainage, Mundt said, all

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INSIDE

Thousands rally

“No Kongs” rally in Grant Park draws thousands bearing colorful posters, flags and pro-democracy slogans. **Chicagoland, Page A3**

Houthis join war

Iranian-backed Houthi rebels entered the war in the Middle East, claiming missile launches at Israel. **Nation & World, Page B5**

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